

Leibniz on the Concepts of Archive, Memory, and Sovereignty

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“Enfin, troisièmement, faire ressortir les rapports de domination plutôt que la source de souveraineté, cela voudra dire ceci: ne pas essayer de les suivre dans ce qui constitue leur légitimité fondamentale, mais essayer, au contraire, de chercher les instruments techniques qui permettent de les assurer.”

Michel Foucault, *Il faut défendre la société*¹.

In his *Political Treatise*, Spinoza asserts that the right and power of States vary according to the degrees they approach “absolute dominion” [*absolutum imperium*]. The word “absolute” and its variants are pervasively present throughout the book. Spinoza explains it by referring to the “absolute freedom” of God in the book’s second chapter, and characterizes democracy as “perfectly absolute dominion” [*omnino absolutum imperium*]² in the beginning of the book’s last and unfinished chapter. This last passage indicates that a State is more “absolute”³ than another when it achieves a better balance among the powers and counterpowers working within it. As it is well known, Spinoza criticizes one of the central tenets of Hobbes’ theory of sovereignty, which holds that citizens must transfer all their natural rights to the sovereign.⁴ At the superficial level, Spinoza’s critique could be understood as based on his intention to formulate a realistic account of political phenomena.⁵ A more profound reason guiding Spinoza’s critical remarks on Hobbes is as follows: if one cannot absolutely transfer one’s power to the sovereign, this is because the “power of the multitude” always remains functioning as a

¹Michel Foucault: *Cours au Collège de France*, 1976, Paris 1997, 39.

²*Tractatus politicus*, chapter 11; G V, 220.

³It could sound strange to say that a thing is “more” or “less” absolute than another, as the word “absolute” in its etymological meaning signifies being perfectly accomplished. Nevertheless, Spinoza employs the expression frequently in *Political Treatise*. For example, in § 8 of chapter VI, he establishes a proportion between the right of a sovereign and the amount of power transferred to him: “... regem eo minus sui juris, et subditorum conditionem eo miseriorem esse, quo magis absolute civitatis jus in eundem transfertur”; G V, 73. The idea of “degrees of absoluteness” may be derived from Descartes’ deductive series, in which the most simple and absolute element should be placed in its beginning (cf. *Méditations métaphysiques*; AT VII, 69; IX, 55 and *Regulæ ad directionem ingenii*, Regula X; AT X, 384–385).

⁴Hobbes admits that there are some limit cases where one could legitimately resist the sovereign in order to save one’s own life.

⁵This is how it seems to be defended in chapter XVII of the *Theological-Political Treatise*, weakening the Hobbesian thesis presented in the previous chapter. Leibniz’s critiques to Hobbes will also appeal to the supposed “unrealistic” components of Hobbes’ “absolute view.” Cf. *Cæsarinus Fürstenerius (De Suprematu Principum Germaniæ)*, a text written by Leibniz only a year after his arrival at Hanover: “Hobbes’ fallacy lies in this, that he thinks things which entail inconvenience should be not be borne at all [...] But experience has shown that men usually hold some middle road...” in: G.W. Leibniz: *Leibniz, Political Writings*, translated by Patrick Riley, Cambridge 1972, 1988, 119.

counterpower in the interior of the States, with the possible exception of democracy.⁶ Human essence would be destroyed if the totality of one's powers is transferred to another more powerful individual.

Leibniz's theory of sovereignty is often compared with those of the two illustrious antecessors. These comparisons typically stress that Leibniz could be located closer to Spinoza than to Hobbes as they both criticize the Hobbesian notion of absolute sovereignty as an unrealistic account of politics.⁷ As mentioned earlier, the latter statement is not the best explanation for Spinoza's critiques, nor for Leibniz's. Although Leibniz defends a "relative" view of sovereignty, he is closer to the Hobbesian concept of State than generally believed. Moreover, Leibniz's relative view of sovereignty cannot be fully understood unless his theory on the nature of sovereign power is complemented with his efforts to implement, in both the practical and theoretical levels, a science of information at the disposal of the government. In summary, making sense of Leibniz's relative view of sovereign power demands an understanding of the epistemological aspect of the notion of government.

One central piece of such science of information is the organization of archives. In his first years in Hanover, from 1678 to 1680, Leibniz proposed⁸ the foundation of a unified central archive, first to Duke Johann Friedrich and then to his successor, the Duke Ernest August, after the former's death. Among the last documents written by Leibniz on this subject is *On the Utility of the Foundation of an Archive*⁹. In this admonition to the Duke, Leibniz characterizes archives as the way science pertaining to Princes could be institutionalized in a *spatial* realm, that is, both in the *written* signs and documents charged to materialize memory and in the *building* containing information useful for the achievement of goals of a sovereign power. As some modern theories on archive admits¹⁰, archival institutions do not limit themselves to registering public memory but *constitute* it through their activities of selecting, ordaining, publicizing, and, in certain cases, concealing the documents they collect and preserve. The document sent to the Duke defines archives as follows:

"An Archive is thus such a place where writings useful for government [*zur Regierung dienlich*] are kept in such a way that they rest intact and unaltered [*unversehret und unverändert beybehalten*] for future

⁶As *Political Treatise* remained unfinished, Spinoza's opinion on the matter cannot be ascertained. Although, he seemingly suggests that a direct and non-representative democratic government is the "most absolute" as there would be no need of a "counterpower" to balance the power of the sovereign.

⁷Cf. Patrick Riley: Introduction to Leibniz, in: *Leibniz, Political Writings*, 28. Cf. also Stuart Alden: *The Birth of Territory*, Chicago & London 2013, 321. Cf. note 5 above.

⁸Cf. Letter to Herzog Ernest August, Spring of 1680; A I, 3, 29.

⁹Von *Nützlicher Einrichtung eines Archive*, Mai–June 1680; A III, 4, 332–340, partially translated by Louis Alexandre Foucher de Careil, in: Leibniz: *Leibniz. Œuvres*, Paris: Didot Frères, 1859–75, vol. VII, 127–137). Other important documents must be taken into account in a more fully developed approach of this topic such as the memorandum Leibniz wrote in 1678 titled *Was in der Canzley oder Regierung zu thun*; A III, 4, 330–332; *Entwurf gewisser Staats-Tafeln*; A III, 4, 340–349; *Einrichtung einer Bibliothek*; A III, 4, 349–353; and *Brief an Herzog Johann Friederich von Hanover*, Fall of 1679; A II, 1, 754. On the historical contextualization of Leibniz documents on archives, see Lotte Knabe: "Leibniz' Vorschläge zum Archiv- und Registraturwesen", in: *Archivar und Historiker*/hrsg. von der Staatlichen Archivverwaltung im Staatssekretariat für Innere Angelegenheiten, Berlin 1956, 107–120.

¹⁰Especially the ones derived from Michel Foucault's and Jacques Derrida's concepts of archive. A similar methodological approach can be found, among others, in the work of Roger Chartier. See, for example, his book *L'Ordre des livres. Lecteurs, auteurs, bibliothèques en Europe entre XIVE et XVIIIe siècle*, Aix-en-Provence 1992.

information [zu künftiger nachrichtung], and that in that occasion they can be used as certified proofs in justice.”¹¹

On that account, the difference between “science” [*Wissenschaft*] and “information” [*Nachrichtung*]¹² formulated at the beginning of the document is presented by the contrast between “what is useful for anyone to know” [*was männiglich zu wissen dienlich*] and “what concerns us and not others” [*was nicht iederman, sondern Uns vor andern angehet*]¹³. Hence, it is introduced by the contrast between an *absolute* and a *relative* type of knowledge. “Information” is the wisdom of a Prince¹⁴, and the archive is the physical expression of a memory containing the registry of political treatises, genealogical lineages, frontiers, public employees, and economical activities of the territory under rule. As such, an archive is another way of producing an impersonal mechanism devised to replace a memory’s feebleness and even the death of ancient public servants¹⁵.

Apart from being an auxiliary device to memory, the project involving the foundation of an archive in Hanover coincided with Leibniz’s most intense efforts to develop a “universal language” or a calculus that could be performed mechanically.¹⁶ The similarities between the two projects are remarkable. As described above, the documents kept in a State archive “can be used as certified proofs in justice.” As in the case of the “*caractéristique universelle*,” it is also a means of producing proof and demonstrations: “*toutes les lignes de cette écriture seront autant de demonstrations*”¹⁷. An archive is a repertoire designed not only to keep the past safe but also to constitute an instrument with a fundamental concern over the future actions of a Prince. It has the epistemic value of a virtual mechanism guiding the Prince’s actions.

Leibniz’s well-known relative notion of sovereignty is closely linked to the idea of overlap dominion over territories. Instead of the Hobbesian emphasis on absolute power, Leibniz believes that sovereignty involves complex control and limit mechanisms that regulate the distinct perspectives on how a land and its inhabitants could be divided.¹⁸ To better understand this point, it must be related to his concept of space, particularly to

¹¹A III, 4, 335. The orthography will be registered in the Academy edition.

¹²On this distinction, cf. Markus Friedrich: *Die Geburt des Archivs: Eine Wissensgeschichte*, Oldenbourg 2013, 100.

¹³The expression “*Uns vor andern*” (A III, 4, 334) ultimately points to the territorial frontier that separates natives from foreigners.

¹⁴Cf. Leibniz’s *Portrait of the Prince*, which was offered to Duke Johann Friedrich in 1679: “It is not necessary that princes possess all the varieties of knowledge: it is enough that they know those which are most useful for action and for government...,” Leibniz: *Political Writings*, 92.

¹⁵A III, 4, 335.

¹⁶In the fall of 1679, Leibniz wrote to Duke Johann Friedrich on a “*nouvelle Ecriture ou caracteristique*” that would be “*un organe encor plus utile à l’esprit que les telescopes et microscopes ne sont à la vue*”; A II, 1, 754. On the mnemonic techniques developed in the 16th and 17th centuries, cf. Paolo Rossi: *Logic and the Art of Memory: The Quest for a Universal Language*, Chicago 2000, 5: “The time was right for the development of a conceptual mechanism which, once it was set in motion, could ‘work’ by itself, in a way which was relatively independent of the work of the individual, until one arrived at a ‘total knowledge,’ which would enable man to read the great book of the universe.”

¹⁷Letter to Duke Johann Friedrich; A II, 1, 754. Compare with the following passage of *On the Utility...: “Dienet demnach sowohl außer gerichten zur nachricht, als in gerichten zum beweis”*; A III, 4, 335.

¹⁸This notion of sovereignty was derived from the particular situation of the Holy Roman Empire and House of Hanover in the context of European State-Nations. After all, it was in their name that Leibniz had advocate as a job. However, more than a defense of an old feudal order or an anticipation of modern federalism, Leibniz’s concept of sovereignty as territorial dominion is, as discussed later, a critical way of being in contraposition to parts of the Hobbesian theory of power.

his opposition to the Newtonian concept of *absolute* space.¹⁹ The Leibnizian defense of *relative* sovereignty depends on his notion of *relative* space, or on the perspectival reality of space. In fact, the concept of territory is the instantiation of the two relativistic approaches of space and sovereignty, as territory is a section of overlapping and politically traced spaces. I will characterize archive as the epistemological counterpart of territory or as a virtual mapping of relative space. The first step of this study's analysis consists of the elucidation of Leibniz's concept of archive through his concept of sovereignty. The second one includes instead a proposal of an understanding of the concept of sovereignty in terms of that of archive.

In the first part of the analysis, we should notice that Leibniz's way of justifying the State's legitimacy is not primarily through the concept of absolute sovereign power but through the promotion of welfare and justice – “for our happiness or the happiness of others,” as it appears in the tagline of the X International Leibniz Congress. Nevertheless, he does not contradict Hobbes' claim that among the purposes of political organization is the security of its members. However, the protection of citizens against external and internal forms of menace is not sufficient for Leibniz to legitimize the State as it limits the State's ends to the promotion of balance among the varied powers at stake in a given society. Sovereignty could only be legitimized as a *means* of promoting the true ends of a State, that is its final cause: search for wisdom, justice, and happiness. The *On the Utility of the Foundation of an Archive* seemingly proposes such means of legitimizing the State at the beginning, comparing an archive with the knowledge a good father must have to cultivate a land necessary to maintain the well-being of his family. A Prince is similar to a father in that he takes care of his people through the cultivation of his territory. As such, the project of institutional archives would be more directly linked to the final legitimizing goal of the State, which is its ability to promote happiness. After all, the archive is, among other things, a way of organizing information on resources of a country with consideration of the needs of its people. Therefore, the archive would be in the side of wisdom, not of power. Even questions on the integrity of territory and the right of succession, which can be settled with the aid of archives, would be considered secondary to these more elevated goals.

However, the above first impression is not entirely correct. Going through the list of benefits that Leibniz enumerated in his document to convince the Duke to create a centralized local archive, eight of the ten items are directly related to ways to maintain the sovereign power and not to promote the well-being of the people. This could be attributed to the rhetorical character of the text, that was designed to convince the Prince of the utility of an archive in increasing his power. However, a literal reading of the document is perhaps the best or, at least, the first methodological way of handling it. In fact, items 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 9, and 10 were questions related to rights of succession, privileges, pacts, borders, mutual obligations or favors, and glory of the sovereign and his ancestry. The first item concerns a kind of meta-purpose of any archive, as its aim is to establish which documents the government possesses. Items 7 and 8 are the only ones that do not directly address ways of establishing and maintaining sovereign power; their content concerns the economic resources of the land, such as rivers, mines, ports, irrigation,

¹⁹On this point, cf. Stuart Elden: *The Birth of Territory*, Chicago 2013, 321: “While it might appear that Hobbes's absolute sovereignty and Newton's absolute space defines modern politics and geography, Leibniz's relational views of both are closer to how politics was actually practiced.” Elden's remark accepts the justification Leibniz himself presents in favor of his own theory on sovereignty, viz., its allegedly more realistic account of political phenomena. See above note 5. In a sense, the aim of my communication is to criticize Elden's reading expressed in this passage.

commerce, industry, and currency, and other regulations, along with the implementation of advantages to the territory [*landesvortheiligen Dingen*]. Nevertheless, these two economics-related topics are immediately linked, in item 8, to the political and juridical realms, including police and war regulations. This happens as questions on territory are related not only to public welfare and to wisdom but also, and perhaps mainly, to the notion of sovereign power.

The Hobbesian tradition defines sovereignty by means of a contractualist vocabulary, including “transfer of rights,” “representation,” and “instrumental reasoning,” from which other themes would follow, such as the wise governance of territory and population. In contrast, Leibniz puts the idea of territory administration at the center of his definition of sovereignty²⁰. Thus, in Chapter XI of *Cæsarinus Fürstenerius*, written in 1677, he characterizes the “union” proper to a sovereign State as the formation of “a new civil person.” He states, “For a union, it is necessary that a certain administration be formed, with some power over the members”²¹. “Some power” is distinct from “absolute power.” In a French summary of *Cæsarinus Fürstenerius*, he stresses this relative notion of power, “Sovereign is he who is master of a territory [...] *powerful enough* to make himself considerable in Europe in time of peace and in time of war, by treaties, arms and alliances”²². This is the reason why the document on archives examined in the present study begins with a territorial metaphor suggesting that a Prince is similar to a father who takes care of a farm for the sake of his family. The metaphor is particularly apt in capturing the meaning of the economic items in the above-mentioned list, as they characterize archives as a type of map of a territory; archives depict its natural resources, geography, and the human modifications in it, and should be supplemented by a synoptic board that would intuitively exhibit all information relevant to a Prince.²³ In his critique against absolute sovereignty, Leibniz proposes that the true unity of the State is to be defined in terms of the wisdom that governs the political body. A Prince must be just, wise, and temperate; the government must be the expression of his more elevated and rational nature. The adoption of this Platonic view of justice as a kind of proportion, harmony, or relation²⁴ is what allows Leibniz to represent distinct *degrees* of sovereignty. Sovereignty is defined not by its origin, as contractualist theories suppose, but by the final cause²⁵. Therefore, a *relative* concept of sovereignty can be defended insofar as the exercise of sovereignty approaches this goal.

Thus, Leibniz agrees with Hobbes in at least one important point: *if* sovereignty would be an end in itself, that is, *if* it were defined purely in terms of the exercise of dominion, then a confederate State like 17th-century Germany could not be legitimate, as it would lack unity. The contractualist view affirms that anything less than absolute power

²⁰Cf. on this point Carl Schmitt’s *Der Nomos der Erde im Völkerrecht des Jus Publicum europæum*, 4th edn., Berlin 1997.

²¹*Cæsarinus Fürstenerius (De Suprematu Principum Germaniæ)*, in: Leibniz: *Political Writings*, 117.

²²*Entrétiens de Philarete et d’Eugène*, Leibniz: *Œuvres*, vol. VI, p. 347. *Apud* Riley, in: Leibniz: *Political Writings*, 27 (emphasis added).

²³“... in einem augenblick hauptsächlich zu instruiren” (letter to Herzog Ernest August, Spring of 1680; A I, 3, 30). Cf. a document written at the same time of the one dedicated to the institution of a *Hauptarchiv* (Spring of 1680), titled *Entwurf gewisser Staats-Tafeln*: “Ich nenne Staats-Tafeln, eine schriftliche kurze verfaßung des Kerns aller zu der Landes-Regierung gehörigen Nachrichten, so ein gewisses Land insonderheit betreffen, mit solchen Vortheil eingerichtet, daß der Hohe Landes-Herr alles darinn leicht finden[,] was er bey ieder begebenheit zu betrachten[,] auf einmal übersehen, und sich deßen als eines der beqvämsten instrumenten zu einer löblichen selbst-regirung bedienen könne”; A III, 4, 341.

²⁴Cf. Riley’s Introduction to Leibniz: *Political Writings*, 22.

²⁵In his “monadological period,” Leibniz characterizes the monad’s unifying role through final causation, giving room for different overlapping individualities to conjointly exist.

would constitute only another party at war in the state of nature. If Leibniz does agree with this counterfactual (Hobbesian) assertion, then he is closer to Hobbes than to Spinoza, who *both* defines sovereignty as dominion *and* believes that it comports degrees. Following Leibniz, if a confederate State is to be rationally grounded, its foundation must be looked for as an entity whose nature allows degrees. Wisdom and justice are candidates in point: they both can be conceived as “more” or “less” implemented. In this context, archives, conceived as elements of “the science of the Prince,” are ways of implementing the relative view of sovereign power defended by Leibniz through applied knowledge. Hence, archives are not only on the side of wisdom but also of power. Moreover, archives might be on the side of wisdom only to satisfy a certain strategy of power.

The discussion above has placed the understanding of the concept of archives in the general framework of Leibniz’s notion of sovereignty. The project of creating a unified archive would be a means to ground a relative view of political dominion. Meanwhile, the discussion that will follow explains Leibniz’s notion of sovereignty through the concept of archive. According to the proposed inversion, archives and other institutional apparatuses of government are not to be seen as a means of exercising an already pre-existent political power but are instead their constitutive elements.

Leibniz admits, with Locke²⁶, that private property and other forms of social arrangements predate the institution of States. In contrast, Hobbes proposes that the right to property exists only after the arbitrary constitution of a political body.²⁷ On the subject of property and territory, however, the State for Leibniz does something more than simply being the guarantee of certain previously given “natural rights,” as Locke supposed. Leibniz’s State promotes a qualitative change in the establishment of relations among members of natural societies. The State achieves this goal through the creation of an *abstract* bond between citizens that surpasses small-sized natural societies.²⁸ It is through this abstract relationship that the idea of territory acquires its reality. At this point, Leibniz’s definition of space in general must be reviewed.²⁹ Since an early stage of his philosophical thought, he defines space as a kind of mental relation ordering the coexistence of bodies³⁰, in opposition to the absolute notion of space put forward by Newton and his followers. At the political level, territorial space is the central tenet of sovereignty and is also composed of various relations, as clearly established in a 1677 text:

²⁶Considering the status of Adam’s possessions in his *First Treatise*, Locke affirms that “Yet his Estate, his Territories, his Dominions were very narrow and scanty, for he had not the Possession of a Foot of Land, till he bought a Field and a Cave of the Sons of *Heth* to bury *Sarah* in.” John Locke: *First Treatise*, in *Two Treatises of Government*, ed. Peter Laslett, Cambridge 1988, X, 136 (citations refer to the 1988 edition), IV, 41; VII, 75. *Apud* Elden: *The Birth of Territory*, 305.

²⁷ “*Propriety* is an effect of Common-wealth [...] the act onely of the Sovereign; and consisteth in the Lawes” (*Leviathan* 24.5, 388/128). As regards the “natural” or “artificial” character of political organization under the form of a State, Leibniz also occupies a middle place between Aristotle and Hobbes. Cf. on this point Jérôme Griaud: “Lecture politique des *Nouveaux Essais*” in: *Leibniz selon les Nouveaux Essais sur l’entendement humain*, Montréal/Paris, 2006, 291-304.

²⁸Cf. Griaud: “Lecture politique des *Nouveaux Essais*”, 295–296. The duplication of an initial form of sociability in a more elevated and abstract one will be a recurrent aspect of Leibniz’s political thought; see, for example, the idea of a “*république des Esprits*” or “*cité de Dieu*” by the end of *Monadology*.

²⁹Cf., for example, the list of definitions written in 1671 and reproduced in A VI ii 487.

³⁰Cf., for example, the fragment of *Definitions*; Grua, 324.

“And what we call territorial hegemony seems to be identical to what the French call *la souverainé* [...] Once it is understood that territorial hegemony consists in the highest right of coercing subjects, it is obvious [...] that there is contained in it [a] full discretion to command all other things.”³¹

Sovereign power organizes pre-existing private properties in the continuum of political space that overlaps local powers.³² The archives, comprehended as a virtual map of the territory, comprise a way ideal or mental relations are established among local powers and rights.³³ Just as Leibniz later defines space as ideal relations grounded in monad’s perceptions, in an analogous way territory was already understood in the 1680s as the result of ordained information that allows the sovereign to *perceive* his land as a unified reality.

The political perception of a Prince is primarily directed toward the past; the archive is a repository of the memory of the sovereign. Following Leibniz, memory is not to be understood as a pure mental faculty existing independently of its bodily counterpart. Even before the Paris period, Leibniz had developed his original view on the relationship between memory and written signs, a view that goes far beyond the traditional mnemonic techniques of his time.³⁴ The “*caractéristique universelle*” denotes a way of exposing this view that visual or tactile signs are not merely “auxiliary to memory.” The latter argument had been suggested by Descartes³⁵; for Leibniz, these signs are constitutive elements of it: there is no thought in general and no memory in particular without sensible images. When, later in his intellectual career, Leibniz exposes his theory on the relationship between the mind and the body, stating that there is always an expression of the mental realm in material bodies and vice versa, the epistemic and ontological conditions of this parallelism will be completely systematized. However, since the time of his earlier works on the retention of past perceptions, memory was linked to the ability of representing spatial relations. The archive is, thus, *both* a political institution that constructs territorial unity through the preservation of written documents *and* a virtual mapping of the territory thus constituted.³⁶ Indeed, the archive could not constitute the spatial reality it “depicts” (the territory) unless it were itself spatial, as only material phenomena could be the cause of other material ones. Thus, temporal relations must be spatially given as *actual* signs and *virtual* maps to be adequately represented.

In other documents on the administration of the State written in the same period, Leibniz frequently associates the informational institutions with spatial representations.

³¹Cæsarinus Fürstenerius (*De Suprematu Principum Germaniæ*) Chapter X in: Leibniz: *Political Writings*, 115–116.

³²“[...] it is clear that many regal rights [*regalia*] are excepted, either by express pacts, or oaths, or by provincial custom, and that the territorial hegemony remains intact nonetheless,” Leibniz: *Political Writings*, 116. On the relation between the distinct levels coexisting in spatial analysis, cf. Yves Lacoste: “L’escamotage du problème capital des échelles, c’est-à-dire de la différenciation des niveaux d’analyse” in: *La géographie, ça sert, d’abord, à faire la guerre*, Paris 1985.

³³In the third item of the document on the utility of archives, we read that “Vors 3.) dient das Archiv einem Herrn seine eigne possession und jura zu handhaben, und sich gegen ander Herrschafften vermeintliche Praetensiones, actiones, und Klagten, durch wohl gegründete Exceptiones, und gegen-praetensiones, auch wohl reconventiones zu schützen, immaßen sich oft begibt, daß Unsere Nachbarn einige gerechtigkeiten gegen Uns, oder an unsern Landen gehabt, davon sich beständige nachricht in ihren Archiven findet...”; A III, 4, 336.

³⁴Cf. on this point Marcelo Dascal: *Leibniz. Language, Signs and Thought*, Amsterdam/Philadelphia 1987, especially Chapter 3 (“Signs and Thoughts in Leibniz’s Paris Notes”), 47–60.

³⁵For Descartes, the “intellectual memory” is doubled by a “bodily memory.” Cf. *Regulæ*, AT X, 416.

³⁶In this interpretation, archives are processes of “territorialization” in the sense this term has in Gilles Deleuze’s political philosophy. Cf., for example, Gilles Deleuze and Felix Guattari: *Capitalisme et schizophrénie I : L’Anti-Œdipe*, Paris 1972.

In the document *The Foundation of a Library*, written by the end of 1680, he lists the items that show the value of such an institution, including the following:

“Pour la milice, voicy des plans des villes, des relations des sieges et batailles [...] Pour les affaires du temps voicy des memoires, des actes et negotiations, des recueils des traités de paix, treuves, confederations, querelles, pretensions et interests des potentats. [...] Cartes des pays; voyages curieux qui en decouvrent le fort et le foible des nations, leurs avantages et adresses...”³⁷

And in a letter to Duke Ernest August on the creation of a unified archive in Hanover, also dated 1680, Leibniz associates the foundation of the local archive with the composition of a manual where the Duke could find “a Topography of his land”³⁸. This virtual space is certainly a relational one as the construction of the political, economic, and juridical maps of the territory is the result of variegated relations among the multiple pieces of information the archive organizes. In other words, the territory is not an entity *per se*; the very act of registering it in the archive is what constitutes its (political and juridical) reality.

To see this more clearly, notice that the above-mentioned definition of archive begins with the following words: “An Archive is thus *such a place* [*Ein Archiv demnach ist ein solcher orth*] where writings useful for government are kept ...”³⁹. Apart from being a virtual mapping of a political territory, an archive is also essentially defined by being a *location*, an actual point in space.⁴⁰ As such, the conclusive remarks following the list of ten items establishing the utility of archives contained in the text under examination⁴¹ are devoted to the internal *architecture* an archive must have to fulfill its ends. The juridical authority of the archive depends on its building, which preserves documents to be “intact and unaltered,” a building that transitively rests itself “intact and unaltered.” Leibniz states that the building must be protected to adequately preserve the documents from mold, mice, and worms as well as from fire and attack of enemies. He adds that its internal vaults should be reinforced and doors should be made of iron. The most important original documents should be kept in a safe and hidden in a wall. Leibniz’s recommendations express both his practical concerns with the conservation of documents and his theoretical consideration with the spatiality necessary to the archive to constitute the spatial reality of the territory; it is not enough that it be a virtual representation of space, it must be *actually* spatial.

The reunion today in this Leibniz Congress, celebrating the memory of Leibniz in the city in which he lived for the most part of his life, protracts in a way his thoughts on the institution of a *Hauptarchiv*. The fact that the *Gottfried-Wilhelm-Leibniz-Gesellschaft* also celebrates the 50th anniversary of its foundation in Hanover only serves to stress this inheritance and to confirm the relation between political power and the institution of archives. Every one of us, in a way, is dedicated to construct a Leibniz archive. If an archive is, as it has been presented above, a political way of creating and maintaining the dominion of a territory, it would not be irrelevant to think of the role Leibniz’s figure plays in today’s construction of national identities, especially in Germany. However, not only in it, as it is made evident by the numerous studies on the

³⁷A III, 4, 351.

³⁸A I, 3, 30.

³⁹A III, 4, 335 (emphasis added).

⁴⁰Jacques Derrida has already pointed out that the concept of archive essentially involves the geographic notion of “domiciliation”; it is always in the “house arrest that archives take place,” Jacques Derrida and Eric Prenowitz: “Archive Fever: A Freudian Impression” in: *Diacritics*, Vol. 25, No. 2 (Summer, 1995), 9–63, 10. For a further development of his thesis, cf. Jacques Derrida: *Mal d’archive*, Paris 1995.

⁴¹A III, 338. From this point on, Foucher de Careil does not translate the text anymore.

“reception” of Leibniz’s works written by researchers from different countries. The opening event of this Congress took place at the *Schloss Herrenhausen*, and the welcome speeches were in part made by national and local political authorities. The history of philosophy, as this discipline is understood today post Hegel, is more concerned with legitimizing sovereign power than it initially seems.

In his book *Mal d’archive*, Jacques Derrida points out the intricate imbrication between the epistemic and political aspects of archives; he reminds us that the word “archive” derives from the Greek “*Arché*,” which “names at once the commencement and the commandment”⁴², the origin and the authority. Although Derrida attempted to describe the “impression” Freud left in the concept of archive, the current work endeavored to do something similar as regards Leibniz’s proposals. However, my conclusion will not go in the same direction as the one pointed by Derrida’s analysis. Derrida emphasizes the role archives play as a way to *conceal* and *hide* information and thus maintain a reservoir of meaningfulness. I would like to end my communication by emphasizing exactly the opposite aspect. In my previous examination on Leibniz’s views on archives, I would like to retain his dubious anticipatory character as regards the political realm. More than an anticipation of modern federalism, I am interested to see how Leibniz’s admonishments on the foundation of a central archive in Hanover anticipated the way the flux of information has dominated contemporary politics to the extent that it has become a self-referent cultural reality, referred mainly to itself as its own end. At the dawn of Enlightenment, Leibniz’s political theory proposed the improvement of the technical means available for the implementation of a rational order. The failure of the Enlightenment project diagnosed by many contemporary thinkers makes Leibniz’s efforts a kind of *symptomatic* premonition. When the most Leibnizian of Samuel Beckett’s characters, the archivist Krapp in *Krapp’s Last Tape*, incessantly listens to his records from the past, there is no *purpose* or *order*⁴³ in his almost contemplative silence. As Asja Szafraniec notes in her recent book on Beckett and Derrida, Derrida’s silence about Beckett, even if he considers him among the most important writers of the 20th century, would find a deeper reason in the crucial distinction present in their respective concepts of archives. Although archives are means of concealing and revealing (or revealing *because* it conceals) for Derrida, they are senseless for Beckett; Krapp would like to “exhaust the archives, in order to be able to ‘breathe that void’.”⁴⁴ In a time when the archives have grown to a point of hypertrophy owing to the Internet and other computational devices, Beckett’s inversion of both Leibniz and Derrida’s accounts of archives could be a way of evaluating the political legacy of the Enlightenment and its dead ends.

⁴²Jacques Derrida and Eric Prenowitz: “Archive Fever: A Freudian Impression,” 9. See also the note in pp. 10–11: “Of course, the question of a politics of the archive is our permanent orientation here, even if the time of a lecture does not permit us to treat this directly and with examples. This question will never be determined as one political question among others. It runs through the whole of the field and in truth determines politics from top to bottom as *res publica*. There is no political power without control of the archive, if not of memory.”

⁴³Compare this with what Baldassare Bonifacio writes in his classical *De Archivis*, first published in 1632, stating in its Chapter IX (*On preserving order in archives*): “We would rightly say that the soul of archives [*archivorum animam*], too, is nothing else than order.” (Bonifacio’s text is translated in Lester K. Born: “Baldassare Bonifacio and His Essay *De Archivis*” in: *The American Archivist*, Vol. IV, Number 4, October 1941, 221–237, 235). Leibniz could not have expressed himself better on this point than Bonifacio.

⁴⁴Especially in Chapter 1, in the sub item “Gathering, Sponging, Archiving,” Asja Szafraniec: *Beckett, Derrida, and the Event of Literature*, Stanford 2007, 32–33.

